runs from my first 21 balls. We gradually start to settle and, taking very few risks, we manage to take our score to 156 for four at tea.

Into the evening, Panesar switches to bowl around the wicket and I am keen to seize the initiative.

In my mind, in cricket, above everything else, you want your opponents to be playing under pressure. Batsmen put pressure on the bowlers by scoring freely; fielders transfer pressure to the batsmen by chasing with such intensity that twos become ones; and bowlers impose pressure by limiting the run rate and taking wickets.

Transferring pressure is always the key in this game and, as we try to secure a foothold in the Test, still trailing by more than 400 runs, I want to put the pressure back on Panesar and the other England bowlers by scoring runs, and so spreading the field. We have to get on the front foot. This is a battle we need to win …

Panesar bowls wide outside off. I'm not tempted and leave it. The next ball is straight, and I play it back to the bowler. Seize the initiative, I tell myself. Transfer pressure. I take two steps down the wicket to the third delivery but Monty sees me coming and bowls quicker and flatter. I prod the ball to mid-on.

This is the game. This is the struggle. I love it. Come on, Monty, what have you got now?

He moves in again and this time he gives the ball a little more air. It's there to be hit and, in an instant, I take a step down the wicket and aim to flick the ball over the head of Jimmy Anderson who is fielding at mid-on. Go on, go on, fly, ball, fly. It doesn't. Anderson stretches and grasps a fine catch two-handed above his head. I am out for 42, having batted for more than two hours and facing 119 balls. It is hardly a slog.

Is that giving my wicket away cheaply? I don't know. Perhaps it was.

Ashwell continues to thrive after I am out and completes an outstanding century, but he receives little support and we are dismissed for 247 and asked to follow on. Batting again, we reach 13 without loss at the